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Jeremy Schon & Greg Ormont

Jeremy Schon and Greg Ormont are guitarists, songwriters, and founding members of Pigeons Playing Ping Pong. This constantly touring band attracts its "flock," a multi-generational group of music lovers who appreciate the Pigeons' balance of musicianship and improvisation infused with humor.

Jeremy and Greg were interviewed via Zoom on March 8, 2024 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased, at 10 AM in the morning, to have Greg Ormont and Jeremy Schon here from the band Pigeons Playing Ping Pong. Welcome, gentlemen.

JS: Thanks for having us.

MR: Yeah, this is just like — I have to say, I don't know how many families around the country can say this, but you have three generations of fans in our family.

GO: Oh wow.

MR: My daughter and her family, our grandkids, are all members of your flock.

GO: And therefore you're the honorary grandfather in the flock?

MR: The honorary flock grandfather I guess.

JS: The grandflocker?

MR: Yeah.

GO: There you go, you're the first — you know there might be other grandfather fans but you're officially deemed the grandflocker.

MR: You know I sense that there might be a song there.

GO: Yeah. You know we have an hour, right? It could be done. That's easy.

MR: Do you fellows get song inspiration from unexpected places?

GO: Most of our songs are written from Zoom interviews so no, it's pretty consistent here. But it is funny how like that little phrase like, you know I think there's a song there with a funny little joke, that's actually one of our more known tunes over the past fifteen years as a band is a song called F-U, that the chorus goes F-U-N-K, spelling funk. But that was — I'm telling you it was generated exactly how we just discussed grandflocker, like it was just one of those quick things that ended up, we took it and ran with it. I think we had our guitars in our hands, that's the only difference. So it could come from that or it can be, you know, sitting down and practicing, coming up with ideas as a group, as individuals. You've just got to be a sponge as a musician, right?

MR: So you have your guitar in your hand and you've got this little phrase, where do your hands first go, Jeremy?

JS: You know? Where do they go? I guess they go to B minor — yeah — they go in so many different directions, it depends on the mood you know. Well like F-U is like all right, this is funk, this has clearly got to be a funk song so I mean I went to like a Dorian minor groove you know? Now it's like easy to go to Afro-beats. You know. I'll put this down.

MR: That's cool. And you used the word I was going to ask you, were you both at University of Maryland?

GO: Um hum.

JS: We both graduated in the class of 2010.

MR: And I noticed they had — I went to their website, they had three jazz ensembles. And I wonder if you were involved in that scene?

JS: No. I mean we enjoyed that scene thoroughly. And you know we took one jazz class when we were in college, which the subject matter was amazing for. But no, I mean I was a marketing and information systems major and Greg was a communications major. We just loved playing music and you know it's always been a passion project for us.

MR: Was it hard for the band to get like rehearsal space on campus being that you weren't music majors?

JS: Well I'll tell you if we did try to get rehearsal space on campus it probably would have been very tough. But we always found someone's basement or garage, which was also tough. And you know we changed locations a lot because people would get noise complaints and then we'd have to move on, like, "All right well I guess we can't practice in Sam's garage anymore."

MR: Did the group evolve from a cover band? Most bands when they start rehearsing they may have a goal to like, "Let's play some gigs." So in order to play gigs you have to play what people want to hear I guess. And did you evolve from playing covers to then inserting your own original material? Greg do you want to field that question?

GO: Sure. Yeah I mean we did start playing covers early on. We did, from the beginning we always did our own spin on covers and, you know, we started as an acoustic duo and would mash-up two songs into one or change the genre of the cover we're playing. But yeah I mean we did want to, you know after meeting in the dorm rooms and playing we did want to play out. We wanted to play in front of people and when you don't have a lot of material you can certainly play others to get the ball rolling and get the cobwebs off and get the momentum of playing live under your fingers. And we did start with covers but very quickly inserted our originals. It was almost like a band-aid until we had enough to garner a full set.

JS: Yeah. It was definitely a mix. And also it's just really fun playing songs that you love you know. We've always enjoyed having the chance to play some of our favorite songs. And like it really started off as just a jamming in the dorm room to like oh let's play this

song that we both really enjoy, and then we were playing it for ten people at the coffee shop. And now we probably don't play that song anymore but maybe we play a different cover song that we all love as a band you know. The whole premise is still the same, you know we're having a lot of fun playing music it's just that more people show up now.

MR: A lot more. If you're riding in a — do you ride in a van or a bus usually on your tours?

JS: It really depends on the weekend and the run you know. If it's an extended tour where we're out for at least like four nights to three weeks then we can sometimes take a tour bus. But otherwise we'll tour in a Chevy 15-passenger van and trailer.

MR: I remember those days, and I wonder, there's a term in music of course called paying dues. And did you guys go through those five-in-a-motel and you know, taking as many crackers from the restaurant as you could to get through this particular series of gigs?

GO: Early on five-in-a-motel sounds great. Because we were on people's floors you know. After each show in our first few years we would go out in the crowd and make friends, 'cause (A) we're social people and (B) we needed a place to stay. So we would meet people, chat, find out what their situation was and then meet up as a band it's like, "Okay I found someone with two couches but they have to wake up early." Or "I found, you know a pull out bed but they're having an after-party so it might be hard to sleep. So there was, I think one of the lower points, while I really look at it like romantically like I think this is part of the process, but I woke up next to cat litter one morning after playing a gig, it's like what people think we do and what we actually do, right? Now we're fortunate that, you know sometimes we have a tour bus or we definitely have a bed to sleep in, and dues were paid but, if I could recommend paying your dues in your early twenties that's probably for the best. Mid-thirties would be a little tougher but you know for the love of the music I'd wake up next to kitty litter again.

MR: Oh that is a great quote that we're going to have to use down the road.

GO: You got your quote? Perfect. Headline.

MR: I know exactly what you're saying because I was in this business when I was in my thirties and I thought why am I doing this now, it should have been like ten years ago, earlier. Did you have a sense of what it meant to "make it" in the business? Did you have goals, those nights you were sleeping on couches and you're thinking about where are we trying to go with this?

JS: I mean yes and no. I mean first like you know we were really, we were just having a great time just traveling around the country playing music for people, meeting new people everywhere we went. And we were just like hey, how can we, let's keep riding this. You know let's see where this takes us you know. But you know when we started the band you know there was no like, oh we're going to start this band and we're going to play in this band for thirty years. Like 16 years later it's amazing and such a gift that we're still a

band and you know who could have like seen that happening when we were in the College Park dorms like 16 years ago.

MR: Yeah you've been together longer than The Beatles. Maybe you should go for the Rolling Stones you know, break their record.

JS: I'm down.

GO: Yeah. We started early enough.

MR: Yeah. When you get — I'm wondering if there's ever been a tune that you're working on, and you've got this great groove going, a set of chords, and maybe you have a vocal but aah, it's just not working. And have you ever had the circumstance where you just make it an instrumental?

JS: I don't know if we've ever gone, made a vocal tune instrumental, but we've definitely taken instrumental tunes and added vocals. I mean we've definitely, we've had tons of songs that like you know we'll play as a group in rehearsal and sometimes it don't gel or sometimes it's like aah, this doesn't feel right. And sometimes they'll kind of get put on the shelf. But I'm not sure if we've ever taken a vocal tune and turned it instrumental. But I like the idea.

MR: Well when I listen to the song "Horizon" which you've been doing what for ten years now, it's got that beautiful vamp in the beginning with those two guitar lines and it lasts a long time. And you're not really — this of course is just my opinion — you're not really jamming, you're playing this thing for 32 bars or whatever, and when you recorded that did you feel like it doesn't need anything more than that, we're just going to do that for quite some time and then we're going to add something on top of it and do that for another 16 bars. I'm just trying to get into your head how that worked.

JS: You've cracked the code. I mean we've, as a band you know and as individual people, we've always, I mean we all listen to a lot of instrumental music, especially like kind of groove-oriented instrumental music you know like people like John Scofield more in the jazz world. And like we love to be able to vamp on a cool groove. If there's anything that, you know, for "Horizon" I feel like we thought all right, the simple guitar melody that's happening is very simple, but it catchy enough. And I don't know, somehow we felt that we didn't need full-on vocals you know. And yeah. But we love to ride a vamp you know.

GO: And in those instances you know, like Jeremy wrote the bulk of that song and when he does he'll send them my way usually or I'll be sitting next to him in college or whatever the time period is. And I'll think about adding vocals, almost always, where we sing often. We have a lot of instrumentals but the majority have vocals. And the intro I ended up, you know coming across this like idea, and the song kind of harkened me back to some other concerts I've been to where there's a vamp that's building and you kind of

soak in the bliss of it. You soak in the patience of it and just kind of be there in the moment, and you know it's kind of the preparation before the build. You know? And intro vocals talk about this, like I walk into the show, I finally hang my coat, you know, find my seating and enjoy the show. And then the song basically starts and I thought it was so like peaceful and warm and happy that it can live on its own and after the entire journey of the song where it goes from happy and peaceful to like has the minor, you know solo section, the jam section that adds a lot of tension, builds, builds, builds with anticipation, and then finally crashes into a triumphant chord progression. That to me was like okay if the intro is me walking into the show, the instrumental section is the concert, and as I walk out feeling happier than I did when I came in all I could say is celebrate the people you love, which is the anthem at the end of the song. So for me like that was kind of a conceptual thing where, you know, it kind of encapsulated a night out at a fun concert where — oh that's my cat Emmy — all you can say is like I got there, the music overtook me, and at the end just celebrate the people you love. You know? It was kind of a conceptual decision to withhold the vocals in the middle.

MR: Oh it's Beethovenesque.

JS: That's another first.

GO: Beethoven used the same four chords.

JS: Yeah if Beethoven used four chords, you heard it here with Monk the Grandflocker.

MR: Well the extended section sitting like that and they make the changes that much more effective, when they finally get there, of course you're building the volume and the bass and drummer adding their thing. I guess I'm just, I admire it but I've noticed, Jeremy, the same, a similar thing about your soloing. I can imagine a music theory class where the professor might say, "Notice how Mr. Schon used motivic development and thematic inflection in his solos" because they just seem really well thought out and not random.

JS: Thank you, first of all, appreciate that. I take that as a compliment. You know usually I mean they're 80 percent improv you know. There's some songs that I will write a solo for and actually play that solo. But you know when we're improvising you know we try hard to like give people something they can kind of latch on to so I think motifs are really important in that way. And it allows us to kind of use some repetition and be patient to let it build gradually you know, versus quickly soar right to the top.

MR: Did you ever do any comparison to the length of the particular songs on your LPs and compare them to what you do live with the same song?

JS: Oh they're pretty different. You know the studio, we want people, when people are at a concert, they're in the moment you know. There's the light show, there's everyone around them, there's a huge energy in the room. And, you know similarly, like Greg was saying about "Horizon," we want people to ride that wave and let it build patiently you

know, and stretch it out as long as we see fitting in that exact moment. You know it's a whole experience live. But in the studio package people are listening in their cars or sitting at home and they might not have the patience. They either listen to the 15 minute version of said song. So sometimes the five minute version will be what people listen to at home but then they get to come to the show and experience us stretching it out and taking it for a ride.

MR: Are there things you do in the studio to try to capture that live excitement? Can you actually — do you record all four of you at the same time? And can you see each other in that kind of set up in the studio?

JS: Yeah we record all, I mean we start off every album we've ever recorded we record in a big live room, usually at Wright Way Studios in Baltimore, where we have drums set up on one side and we're all set up on the other side. Everyone's kind of in a circle, similar to how we set up for band practice. And yeah, we just give it our all, you know, try to capture as much energy in each take while also trying to make it the perfect take. And you know we try to incorporate as much into our studio material as possible, whether it be guests, like some cool overdubs, a lot of guitar harmony over here, just to spice it up, just to give it that extra little edge that sets it apart from what we do with it live. Just 'cause we can't encapsulate the full energy of a thousand people in a room, a light show, and that fan band energy interchange in the studio. Like, it's not really possible. So we try to put as much else that we can think of into our studio recordings to give them that extra boost.

MR: Well Greg, when you do your vocals in the studio to you sing while you're playing or do you do it after the fact?

GO: No, I am afforded the luxury of not having to play two instruments at once with singing and playing, so I'm able to really focus on the vocals and conversely I'm able to really focus on my guitar playing when we're laying down the foundation of the songs together because I don't sing during those group sessions. It's more so about the instrumentation and the drumming when we play the initial track together. Afterward, once we've worked on the individual parts I come into the studio and just sing, which is really like, it's a luxury, it truly feels like, because I don't have to split my attention so I can be more, I hope accurate and more thoughtful with each piece of what I contribute to the band when I'm recording, which is really nice. The interesting thing is vocally I have no issue like focusing and executing what I need to do. Sometimes it's hard to play the guitar without singing due to muscle memory, you know, so before we go into the studio I'll often practice, as well as practice for the other guys to get through the structure of the song without my voice leading the changes, whether it's verse to chorus or verse to pre-chorus, or this one's a half chorus, this one's a full chorus. If I'm not singing the melodies it's

funny, like even if we play the song fifty times this is like maybe the first or third time we've ever done it where I'm not singing. So it's worthwhile to practice that as well, which we do, and even for my own sake, just to — you know I've found that certain sections it helps for me to even mouth how I sing to get my right hand to do what it normally does when I'm playing and singing.

MR: Yeah you've got this thing down and —

GO: Exactly.

MR: If you don't do it it's weird.

GO: Exactly. It's one way. It's absolutely that you know. It's funny. But it's a fun challenge and we love recording for that reason particularly is like we can really focus on — you know when I'm on stage I love to perform and rock out and connect with the crowd and look at the crowd and not my fingers if you don't need to and jump up and down. And with the excitement of jumping up and down comes a real focus on not pulling your strings and falling slightly out of tune. So it's nice to not have that going on as well and I could just sit and really focus at getting my fingers dead on the fret board you know, keeping the proper strings muted and execute more technically.

MR: "Keeping the proper strings muted." That reminds me of Bucky Pizzarelli telking about Freddie Green and the way he strummed, and that a lot of his strumming was only two or three strings.

GO: Yeah.

MR: Yeah. It's a little aside but regarding strumming and playing rhythm I noticed that you often times have — I don't know if it's a phase shifter or some kind of effect on your guitar that really I think is distinctive with the Pigeons. It gives you a band sound.

GO: Well thank you for saying that, that's definitely one of the hardest things to do, right, is to sound like yourself whether as a guitarist or as a band, and like you said a lot of bands start with covers and inspiration but it's hard to find your voice. I think one of the biggest things that the band has worked on over the past decade plus is honing in our sound and filling space without a keyboardist or a percussionist per se. So most instrumentation includes keyboards and the fact that we don't have that has really informed my playing because where a keyboard would fill in gaps and, you know, lay down textural pads, that falls more so on my territory. I mean we all take turns but it's kind of forced me to learn to comp and support the band and help elevate the other players by filling space, almost like as a keyboard would. So with that comes, yeah, some phasing, I use a lot of my wah pedal combined with a delay pedal and a volume sweep on the guitar itself, so you're hearing less attack, you're hearing less a guitarist and more so of swelling textures that — a lot of times when Jeremy is taking a solo I don't want to sound like a guitar. We already

have one that's screaming so I almost want to create some contrast for him to poke out more.

MR: Yeah I was listening to a tune yesterday, I can't recall the name but it was near the beginning I said, "Oh there's a Wurlitzer electric piano in there." And it was you. So it definitely works.

GO: Maybe. And for what it's worth I mean in the studio it's another opportunity where we can afford to have maybe some background keys or add a percussionist, or maybe add a horn section here where we don't have the opportunity to do that live every show. So it's another opportunity to, you know, fill sonic space, to try something new, to collaborate with phenomenal musicians, and elevate the track for the studio setting. And then when that happens live when we have a guest on stage it's like adding a new spice to a stew, like it's what is this, this is bright, this is exciting, not just for us but hopefully for the crowd as well.

MR: Do you depend on outside ears when you're doing a recording, especially in the mixing? Do you have a producer or do you just sort of do it yourself?

JS: So we work, we've been working with this guy Steve Wright at Wright Way Studios for probably ten years now. And I mean you know he runs the studio, he's like the lead engineer there. And he's got an amazing ear. He'll tell us instantly after taping like, "Oh you were just barely out of tune, do it again." We spend a lot of time tuning. But he will give us as much feedback as we kind of ask for you know. Often times we'll be like, "Hey we're torn between these two songs. Which one do you think would fit this group of songs for a record more?" And he'll give us feedback and you know sometimes we'll be like, "You're right" and you know it helps be a tiebreaker, you know sometimes when the band is just torn and we just like can't make a decision on our own we'll call in Steve and be like, "Hey, what do you think we should do?" And often times we'll ask other musicians just for feedback if we're just like stuck in a spot or just really indecisive you know. But we've never worked with like a true like producer, someone who kind of gets in there, works on the songs with us before, and the whole pre-production to the studio to the thing. We haven't done that yet. Maybe one day we will but as far as we're concerned Steve is our producer and he does an amazing job. He's incredibly patient —

MR: Are you all in the booth when things are mixed?

JS: Sometimes. More or less though he'll mix like after a session or he'll mix months or weeks after a session and he'll just send us a Dropbox link with a bunch of mixes and we'll sometimes get together or sometimes just individually send notes. But often times we will go in for a mix or added sessions and it's really fun.

MR: I remember the days when, you know the band would all be in the booth and people are asking, "Okay which fader is mine?" so that they could come up and like — everybody wanted more of themselves.

GO: That's when the engineer creates some dummy faders on the side.

MR: The dummy fader.

GO: You could have all three of these.

MR: Okay name this Pigeon song [scats]
Obviously I didn't sing it very well.
[scats]
It's an instrumental guitar riff. Okay time's up. Well I was trying to sing "Havana."

JS: "Havana!" You know I was about to say "Havana" but I wasn't a hundred percent sure.

GO: Oh okay.

JS: I really was.

MR: Yeah if I look at my notes here you know I have this motif thing down I wrote. And that is I think a great example of this lick that rhythmically repeats itself many times but you've got these little changes in there. Where did that come from?

JS: That was one of my favorite ones when I was writing it. Like that really — because it was very interesting. It's in a harmonic major key, which is a bit strange.

MR: Can you explain that?

JS: So it's in the key of G major. I'm 90 percent sure. I've got to think of my guitar. [plays guitar] I don't know, something like that. But it's kind of like an interesting line. It largely wraps over a G major 7. That's like at its center. But then there's a bunch of chords that kind of wrap around this riff that do not really lie in the traditional key of G major. Right. Okay yes, so it's in G harmonic major, which is I believe a G major scale — what is it, a flat six.

MR: Oh there's an E flat in there. Yeah.

JS: Yeah. So it leaves us with a 4 minor chord and also that flat six major seventh. Actually well I guess technically that would be — it should be augmented I guess. But I wasn't thinking of this stuff when I wrote it actually.

MR: It's after the fact usually.

JS: What?

MR: It's after the fact usually — ooh look what I did there.

JS: A guitar student asked me about it and I realized I didn't really know what key it was in. I just, you know it's often better to not think too deeply about the key signature when you're writing because you don't want to limit yourself. Like a lot of earlier songs we wrote you know were very much diatonic, perfectly in a key. But you know when you just kind of use your ear or let your fingers just take you places you know, you're going

to end up with a more interesting product in the end. I mean, usually. And now and then, that one's pretty interesting just 'cause it's a strange chord progression of like G major 7 to C minor 7 to E flat major 7, D 7. It's really, it's kind of, it's almost got like a Middle Eastern vibe to it, but I don't know it's just different.

MR: There's a tune that I can't remember the name of, which I think I ended up trying to vocalize here and it's a very Cuban-sounding thing [scats] like it's not a rumba but it's some kind of dance. And it was reminiscent of that but it's really a great tune so,

JS: Thanks.

MR: Keep playing it.

JS: No I love playing that. I mean that song, it's fun to play and it was actually also challenging, you know I had to practice that a lot to not like blow it live. But yeah, that's a really fun song you know.

MR: You seem to be, the whole band seems to be pretty spontaneous on stage and in watching the videos and actually my daughter mentioned this, watching you live, trying to see what cues are you all giving each other when you're vamping on something, sometimes it's musically apparent that it's building and building and needs — it feels like a change now, but other times I'm just wondering do you have eye contact, body language that moves you from one section to another? Greg, what do you think?

GO: Well I think, like you said a lot of times the music will dictate a need for a change. It depends on if we're in a true freeform section or if we know where the — like no matter what even if it's freeform unless we've decided to play a one song set and truly improvise for 75 minutes, generally speaking we know where the destination is but there are multiple ways of getting there and a lot of times it's as simple as if we feel as though we've taken this route, we've built tension and it's time to release, it's as simple as looking at each other, looking at each other before the one, kind of just being like yup, just a short little nod or even eye contact. And then over time, because we know where the destination is depending on how improvisational the moment is, I could look over at one of the guys and they don't even have to look, they just nod looking forward, and I'm like okay he sees that I'm looking over at him, we're ready to proceed to the next section. When we're in true, true improvisational moments we do have hand signals or body language signals that can be utilized to refer to a chord in the key that we could go to but that is much less common than kind of, I mean we've been playing together for — we've put in the 10,000 hours as a group let alone as individuals, and we know each other's tendencies. We've also learned the hard way that like if there's a sense that one out of the four of us isn't ready to move on, don't move on. You know? 'Cause there's a patience there where even if we have to vamp for another 8 or 16 or 32 we'd all rather go together than you know jump the gun prematurely. So, and fortunately our fans afford us that

luxury. They're there for the ride. You know they're not going to be — "Hey you know the form is off guys."

MR: That's when it's like, "Come on fellas."

GO: Yeah. Enough of this vamp, right? No. So we're patient, we're conservative, and we really keep open ears across the board, whether feeding each other motifs or progressing the structure along.

JS: Yeah. A lot of changes will happen like live with just like, you know, someone will introduce a new chord, you know, Greg will start playing like a D over the A minor that Ben is rolling you know. And then we all hear him and we're like all right, let's follow that. You know. And or Ben could often times introduce a progression when we land into like, oh if we're in a one-chord jam like Ben could suddenly introduce a chord progression on the bass you know, usually revolving around some chord tones to keep it safe at least initially, but you know really it's whatever goes live and we all really have to have open ears at every moment, otherwise we might miss either an audio, a musical cue or a visual cue.

MR: Do you ever break into a swing groove?

GO: Sure. Absolutely. Yeah. We talk about swing and how swung it should be all the time. You know our drummer, we all afford each other a lot of leeway to take it wherever it may be and that's not just how Jeremy described our musical progressions but if the drummer wants to try a new beat like we all just feel it. And I think a large portion of that is, you know the understanding that we have that freedom and leeway, and also a lack of ego for individuals because if someone makes a decision that is pretty finite, like switching a groove, there is no forcing the group back to where it was from us. There's all right, we're taking this turn, one of us took a leap and we're jumping with him. You know like there's no creative struggle when we're improvising. I just think that's so important you know. It's something you learn over time. Like I hear this idea, I totally hear this modulating, and if it's not felt musically or just visually you can sense that the guys aren't ready to move on, if you force it, boy is that not going to work out. You know? So it's really important to be constantly thinking about the group. We're one of four people. That's the minority you know? The group needs to decide where the music goes, not you.

MR: Well said. There was an interesting moment from a video that you were playing on a New Year's Eve and you were playing "Auld Lang Syne." I think you were waiting for the balloons to fall or something, and they weren't.

GO: Which year? That happens every year, Monk. We're cursed with New Year's balloons. Actually this year though I think the curse didn't rear it's head but man there's been multiple, multiple times that the balloons haven't dropped, the string breaks and now how

do you even get the balloons to drop? There was one concert when we were playing a slightly smaller venue, still like a thousand people but not as, like the way that it was set up the string that you used to pull the balloon net were within the crowd and I don't know if the security fell asleep or took a coffee break but a fan pulled it at around 11:40 PM. So needless to say we did not break into "Auld Lang Syne." We say Happy New Year while playing music, in time, at midnight on the dot, whether the balloons are there or not. But yes —

MR: Yeah, they blew the moment. But in this particular thing you all of a sudden started playing "I Get By With a Little Help From My Friends" I think. Now that must have been spontaneous I would guess?

GO: You never know.

MR: You know it's interesting though, Jeremy I assume that you played the melody to that song. Now that doesn't seem oh like so what, big deal. But I know that sometimes on solo piano gigs someone will ask for "Brown Eyed Girl" and I'll go oh my God I've never played the melody to "Brown Eyed Girl" I've just played the chords in a band situation and it's very interesting to be sort of stumped by like how do I actually play the melody?

JS: Yeah it's a fun challenge you know when taking a vocal I mean we've played a lot of covers as instrumentals and it's really fun you know. I mean "Help From My Friends" we've done every version of that song at this point, including an instrumental take that New Year's. You know it is interesting sometimes you'll be like you know the song so well but then it's like all of a sudden you have to play the vocal part on the guitar and it's just a totally different thing. Yeah "Brown Eyed" I'm trying to think of how I'd want to do "Brown Eyed Girl" as like an instrumental. But you know we love taking vocal songs and turning them instrumental. We've done it with countless songs from like Harvey Danger's "Flagpole Sitta" to — a '90s throwback — you know "Eleanor Rigby" which has been done by obviously many people you know. So like "Paint it Black" — there's many songs that we'll take and just make an instrumental version. It's really fun.

MR: Did either of you have an experience, if you look back when you were kids, when we were kids we didn't know what the word "epiphany" meant. But now we do and is there anything that happened that really caught your attention and set you on this musical path?

GO: You know that comes up a lot and you're right, you don't realize it when it happens but if you start to look back there's some moments that kind of seems like it sets you on this path. For me, I mean when I was five years old, in kindergarten, everyone in my school would be in the kindergarten circus, and that would mean there would be dogs on — or clowns on tricycles or whatever. And I was cast as the doggie in the window. And my big line would be, you know, [sings] "How much is that doggie in the window" I'd go "Arf,

arf." Right? Very cute. And people — I remember being on stage and seeing a positive reaction there and that was what got me into — I did a lot of musical theater from age 5 to 17. And that next year my best friend who's still one of my best friends for life, his mother did all of the directing for the musical theater in our community so between catching the bug and then meeting him and starting to do all the plays I found myself singing for the rest of my life. The second piece that I look back on is I grew up in New York on Long Island and my parents would take me to plays on Broadway. And my father is a huge classic rock fan, loves The Who and all of the bands, Clapton, those types of bands. And we went and saw The Who's "Tommy" on Broadway and we got like first few rows, killer seats, and The Who's guitarist, Pete Townshend, was in the pit playing with the band and I was about ten years old. And the combination of musical theater, which I already loved but given a rock & roll edge to it was game changing for me. Like it combined, it took this love for performing and it crystallized with more like contemporary music. And then I was like okay musicals aren't just, you know, ballads and romantic tunes or old show tunes, like it can be rocking, it can be edgy, it can be cool like in a youthful way. And that was — and then frankly like meeting Jeremy on the first day of college, he then opened my ears to an entire different genre of music being more the improvisational stuff, the jazz, the funk, the jam music, and took me to bands like Phish and Soul Live and funk bands and stuff that's just not in the mainstream. And that — my musical journey just took such a hard turn in that direction to the point where, you know when I met him my hair was this long and as you can see it's grown quite a bit along with my musical taste.

MR: How do your parents feel about your career?

GO: They are perhaps too supportive. They retired recently and happily so and they now kind of treat our tour like we did in our twenties where like oh I've never been to Seattle let's play there. And they haven't been to X-Y-Z and they use our tour schedule as like a vacation map and anchor their trips around our shows. And my favorite story with that is I bring — Seattle comes to mind — like I said I grew up in New York as did my folks, and the east coast. And when my father was like 17 his best friend moved to Seattle. And Seattle was very far from New York and you don't really have a lot of reasons to go there if work doesn't take you there or vacation or family. And finally 39 years later his son, me, played in Seattle so he said, "Let's go." He went out there with my mom and he reunited with his friend after almost forty years 'cause he finally had a reason to go, which is the power of music and I'm incredibly grateful to have such supportive parents 'cause it wasn't clear that things would work out when we were waking up next to kitty litter, right? So they're happy I stuck with it and love traveling with us when possible.

MR: That's terrific. Jeremy do you have any AHA moments that you can remember?

JS: I mean I remember what kind of sparked me to really play guitar you know. Like my parents are both musicians and like they always, from a young age they tried to get me to play different instruments but I don't know, I was not the kind of kid who was going to — I wanted to be on my own path. And so I did pretty poorly at like piano at age six. I even tried guitar around that same time and didn't take to it unfortunately. I wish I did, I would be that much better. But when I was twelve my dad had this band. He's a doctor and he had this band of fellow surgeons and doctors called The Stimulators. He still has the band actually to this day. And they had this wild guitar player who could shed like Steve Vai style. And I was like all right, that's really cool. That is what I want to do. And that sort of sparked my interest to actually try the electric guitar you know. I had only tried playing acoustic guitar at that point you know, but that was like all right, I think I want to try guitar again. And for my twelfth birthday I got a Yamaha Pacifica Strat and that sort of paved the way for me. Now that became my new outlet, my new hobby you know, and totally like changed my life you know. It gave me a voice you know. I —like contrary to Greg, I was like terrified of the stage and like I had to be in one play in like eighth grade and I was petrified. But you know having guitar was like all of a sudden it was like okay, I can express myself with this and I remember like giving a talk to my like sixth or seventh grade class about guitar and I actually felt comfortable because I had the guitar in my hands.

MR: Yeah something between you and the people looking at you. You've got a buffer of a sort.

JS: It's a shield. Yeah. But that was really pivotal you know. I still can't shred like Steve Vai unfortunately, I sort of diverged my direction of what I was heading towards you know, but I mean I love playing more than anything. It's really, it's my favorite thing to do.

MR: What's the — when you're traveling and just talking, are there goals in mind? From my observation you've reached goals that you may not have even considered starting out. Where do you go next from here?

JS: The moon.

MR: Or do you just wait and find out?

JS: I go — my route is like I kind of wait and find out. That's always been my thing is just go for the ride and keep expectations in check. But you know there's a healthy balance between me just kind of seeing where it goes. I think Greg has more goals in mind on the other hand. I think there's an important balance there. And Greg correct me if I'm totally off.

GO: Well I wouldn't say, I mean I think more so in the short term on what our goals might be. Like okay we have an album coming out this April, let's — how many singles do we want to release? When should we do that? Should we make more cop —" I'm just like

focusing on what's in front of me to an extent and trust that if you're making incremental progress, you know it's hard to say I want to be 10X better next year. It's a lot easier to say I want to be point 1X better today, and that accumulates. You know? It's a daily thing, and we just care about it so much that we're happy to work on this stuff whether it's music or behind the scenes management type stuff every day. But I mean truly speaking like whether it's our albums or our shows like we just want to make progress, incremental progress. We want this next album to be our best album to date, I mean it's subjective but like we want to feel that it's the most proficient, sophisticated, fun, you know elicits positive emotions, and then either from the management side the release goes smoothly, everything felt like it was planned out appropriately, and at the same time we want every live show to be our most energetic, our most fun, our most exciting, whether it's down to the set list choices, the new transitions, like we've never repeated a set list in probably however many, 1500 shows we've played. It's always a new show, and that's largely for our benefit to keep things fresh and hopefully the fans enjoy that type of choose your own adventure what comes next kind of vibe. But truly we just want to be better than yesterday, and I think the rest will take care of itself. I think it's important to have goals, you know there's the phrase like if you reach for the moon you — or you reach for the stars you'll get the moon but if you reach for Jupiter you might end up with Saturn or you know like I think it is important to have big dreams but I think it's more important to enjoy the process. Because if you're worried about the goal, once you get there then what? You know? You have to make another goal. But for us it's about the process and like leaning into it and enjoying that moment. Because if you're not enjoying that then the goals aren't going to matter. Frankly we're just incredibly grateful to still be doing this and it seems as though momentum is in the right direction and we get to play music for a living so like I think we've already hit our goal you know.

MR: That sounds like you wrapped up for me, this interview. I mean that was like really fairly profound. You said, we try to make every show our greatest. What makes you walk off stage and like — what would make you say that that was just a totally awesome show? Is it partly the audience?

GO: Yeah I mean the first word that comes to mind is energy. You have that trade-off between us as a group and the crowd and the band, just the atmosphere of everything is an endorphin rush that is like no other. But I think also like we're at the point where like every show — knock on wood — every show I think is a fun show for people. I think we've reached the point where we're not going to put on a bad show. You know like we have enough skills and wherewithal to put on a fun experience for everybody, but there's a difference between like putting on a good show and having a good show. You know? And when you feel as though you weren't making major blunders, the improvisational

chances you took like worked as a group. There wasn't those moments where like we all had to check our ego and not go because only half of us were ready. Like when we're all like kind of unconsciously flowing with the music. It's palpable and it's hard to put into words but just know like okay there weren't many roadblocks today in our creativity. It was all — we were all tapped in, our egos were down, our ears were open, and the music flowed through us. Instead of thinking what's next we weren't thinking at all. You know?

MR: Jeremy, do you want to put a coda on that?

JS: Yeah I mean I think Greg nailed that on the head completely you know. I mean enjoying the process of what we do by the way is I think the most important thing if you want to be successful, really you have to enjoy the process. If you don't enjoy the process I think you'll burn out, you're not going to have fun, I mean we love it. I mean everyone says, "Oh you guys have been grinding it out." It's never felt like we've been grinding it out. We've always really had a truly great time whether we were in our busiest years doing 196 shows you know — it was a good time. We had a blast. And yeah we slept on floors but it was fun. And on like having good show thing, yeah, we're always going to give it 110 percent. There's never a crowd that isn't worthy of 110 percent of our effort. You know. We try to play every show as if it's our last show. And you know, and some nights where we just feel more in the zone as a unit you know, that's when it just feels even better for us. Although really every show feels great. We're so lucky to have an audience that just feeds us back so much energy and love and I don't know, we're truly blessed in that regard.

MR: Excellent.

GO: Well I don't want to dismiss goals entirely because I think even with Jeremy's story on his AHA moment, like he played guitar when he was six, it didn't really take, but then he saw what it could lead to. Like I saw "Tommy" and I saw what the musical theater path and the guitar path could be. So it made the process, especially early on when it's very, very challenging or I mean it always is challenging, I knew what I was working toward. It's hard to enjoy the process if you don't know where you're going you know. So it's helpful to have, like fortunately we've been able to play large shows so we know why we're practicing so hard, because there's that huge adrenalin endorphin rush that comes with it and there's a big release that we're building toward so I do think it's important to know where you're going or get a glimpse of what it could be so you embrace the process. You know? Because it's not ultra-fun learning scales but it's incredible when you're taking a solo and you're not thinking about anything. So it's important — there's a marriage there you know.

MR: Well said. Last question, are you familiar with B.F. Skinner?

GO: We have a song called "Skinner." And we didn't know what the intro should be and can you guess what the first two chords are?

MR: Uh, no, I can't.

GO: B F.

MR: B and F, what a relationship!

GO: It happened to work. It's a weird song, but boy, it's rooted in A but.

MR: Okay.

GO: But we were like where should we take this? And it works.

MR: He's a graduate of Hamilton College, where I'm sitting right now.

JS: Oh wow.

GO: Oh really? I didn't know that.

MR: Mid-twenties I think. And so just yesterday my wife said, "Come and look at this." And there's a picture, the video of the pigeons playing ping pong. I swear I'd never seen it before.

JS: It's our only competition. There's no other bands with this band name, that's the only one.

MR: Well this has been so enjoyable and I appreciate your taking your time out to join me, and maybe I'll be in the flock in Utica on May 26.

GO: Bring the whole family, that'd be great. We'd love to have you.

MR: Everybody's coming.

JS: That's a really fun venue.

MR: You've met my grandchildren actually which is pretty cool.

JS: Oh really? How old are they?

MR: They're nine and eleven.

JS: Oh fun, awesome.

MR: And they are fans.

JS: Well if they like music hopefully they can see what joy it brings us and maybe they go on that path you know.

MR: Yeah they're already playing.

JS: That's great, that's great. As long as they enjoy it, right? That's what I always say.

MR: Okay. All right thanks again.

GO: Thank you man, this was awesome.

JS: Appreciate it.

[maybe need to snip the end]